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OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDENT

Jim Scherzinger
Superintendent

March 3, 2003

MEMORANDUM

TO: Board of Education
Portland Public Schools

FROM: Jim Scherzinger
Superintendent

RE: School Closures FY 03-04

On February 3rd I received recommendations from the Space Allocation Committee on school closures and other ways to make more efficient use of our school property. The closure recommendations have generated considerable reaction. Many board members and I have attended community meetings and have met with concerned groups of parents, staff, and community members. All neighborhoods in which school closures are being considered have voiced strong support for their school and for the neighborhood school concept.

I had originally intended to make my closure recommendations as part of my budget recommendations. However, to incorporate the tentative settlement with the Portland Association of Teachers and the accompanying efforts to provide local funding, we have moved our formal budget process back to April. However, I must make recommendations on school closures now to give parents, students, and staff time to plan for next year.

Therefore, we will use the following process:

March 3 **Superintendent Recommendations**

March 6 **Hearing at BESC on Proposed Closures at 6:30 pm – public comment welcome**

March 10 **(Regular Board Meeting) Decisions on proposed closures at 6:30 pm. BESC – no public comment**

March 31 **Student transfer submission deadline at Enrollment and Transfer Center**

Later this spring, I will recommend a school size and closure policy to the Board and ask that each of the following categories be addressed as part of any closure recommendation:

- Data reviewed and space needs based on projected student population
- Education evaluation and special considerations
- Economic efficiency, including projected reuse of building

Today I am attaching the analysis using the categories for the two proposed closures.

Closures Are Still Necessary

The events of the past few days and the prospect of local bridge funding give us hope that we can operate full school years at a level that moves us forward educationally until the state finds a school funding solution. Nonetheless, we must still consider school closures and consolidations because:

- Even with bridge funding of $48 million per year, about $9 million in budget savings are needed to maintain a 30:1 staffing ratio next year.
- Our enrollment continues to decline, especially in elementary schools.
- We are moving forward with efforts to market our administrative buildings. I will have a recommendation on declaring the CSC surplus in June. Recent events indicate interest in the BESC could be picking up soon. Closing these buildings will require us to find space to relocate staff housed in them.

Public Participation Has Been Extraordinary

As a superintendent who has served during some very tumultuous times, I must recognize the extraordinarily helpful and considerate participation by the parents, staff, and community members of affected schools since the Space Committee's recommendations were made. People recognize the difficult situation we are in and are willing to consider many alternatives to closure and, if closure must occur, are willing to make the transition as supportive as possible for children.

Effect of Costs on Decisions

One of the most frequent questions I heard during my review was the effect of cost savings on the decision. For example, it was often pointed out that small schools in small buildings had lower operating costs than similarly small schools in larger buildings. This is not a surprising result, but it is not enough cost information to base a decision on.

Building decisions have long-term effects. In the long run, it makes the most economic sense to right-size our buildings to the desired size for instruction and locate them to best serve the geographic and social diversity of our students.

Thus in some cases it may be more desirable to consolidate two small schools into the larger building if the result is a school within the desired size range for instruction and is well-located for the students it serves. On the other hand, it may be more desirable to improve an existing too-small school if the alternatives are not well-located or are in poor condition.

Recommendations Concerning Specific Schools

I believe the following recommendations of the Space Allocation Committee make sense educationally, and I am recommending them to the Board.

- **Closing Brooklyn School and consolidating with Grout School and expanding Winterhaven**

- **Closing Meek School and consolidating with Vernon School**

These schools are under 200 in K-5 enrollment and are expected to continue to decline in enrollment. (In fact, they are closer to 110 in projected enrollment with students from the neighborhood boundary only.) They can be combined with an adjoining school and maintain an acceptable limit of enrollment. There are educational advantages to both recommendations.

Brooklyn

I recommend that we proceed with the closure of Brooklyn and consolidate the school with Grout Elementary as recommended by the Committee for the following reasons:

- The Brooklyn neighborhood program currently enrolls 120 students. This is well below the draft school size policy and the enrollment of the two schools we closed last year. The area has experienced and is expected to continue an overall enrollment decline.

- There is adequate space at Grout to house the new students, while remaining within the draft guidelines.

- The consolidation will expand the program opportunities available for existing Brooklyn students. (e.g. grade level classes at all levels; Reading Recovery; Portland Impact social services: Arts for Learning; own playground) (A complete report on educational impact is detailed in the appendix.)

- For students who may wish transfer to Winterhaven, five slots per grade level will be given priority status for students currently enrolled in Brooklyn for the FY03-04 school year only.

Meek

Similarly, I recommend that we proceed with the closure of Meek School and consolidate the school with Vernon Elementary as recommended by the Committee for the following reasons:

- The Meek neighborhood program currently enrolls under 110 students. (The balance of approximately 70 students are transfers). The total of approximately 180 is still well below the draft school size policy and comparable to the enrollment of the two schools we closed last year. The area has experienced and is expected to continue an overall enrollment decline.

- There is adequate space at Vernon to house the new students. (Depending on the number of non-neighborhood transfers who go to Vernon, the numbers may slightly exceed the draft guidelines.)
- The consolidation will expand the program opportunities available for existing Meek students. (e.g. Pre K and full day kindergarten; Success for All; computer labs; OASIS tutoring assistance; RIF program; Chess Club) (A complete report on educational impact is detailed in the appendix.)

Edwards

I recommend we not proceed with the Space Allocation Committee's recommendation to close Edwards next year and move its program to Richmond School. Instead, I recommend we, by November, complete a facilitated analysis involving affected members of the Franklin and Cleveland communities with a goal of closing at least one facility in the area while preserving education options available to students within the size policy adopted by the Board. This analysis would be conducted like the analysis described in more detail for Rieke School below. Based on this analysis, I will bring a recommendation to the Board in December.

I make this recommendation for the following reasons:

- Edwards' current enrollment is about 200 and is relatively stable. This is slightly larger than the schools recommended for closure this year and last year.
- The Space Allocation Committee's recommendation warned that it had not resolved whether Edward's year-round curriculum could survive at Richmond. This issue is still unresolved. In fact, subsequent analysis indicates a number of problems with transferring the program to Richmond, including adjustments to the feeder patterns, building issues, and the migration of students to other schools.

- If a successful transfer could be made, the resulting enrollment at Richmond would exceed 600, which is substantially larger than the size policy currently being considered by the Board.
- Enrollment at the neighborhood schools at Sunnyside and Richmond both are less than 120. A more comprehensive analysis may produce better choices than we are currently aware of.
- In the long run, survival of Edwards' year-round curriculum requires a building that will allow Edwards to grow so that it can operate within the size policy adopted by the Board. Edwards has operated for many years under the threat of closure.
- The site council at Edwards has actively taken on the issue of finding alternatives that would ensure the long-run survival of the year-round program. I believe that with further analysis and clarification of our size policy, the site council will work with those of other schools, parent and community groups, and our central staff to come up with a better solution that meets our mutual needs. In the meantime, the site council has made a number of recommendations to reduce costs next year. These will be considered in my budget recommendations in April.

Rieke

I recommend we not proceed with the Space Allocation Committee's recommendation to close Rieke next year and move its students to Hayhurst and Bridlemile. Instead, I recommend that closure or realignment of the boundaries of Rieke be considered as part of the comprehensive realignment of boundaries and feeder patterns across the entire West Side that was also recommended by the Space Allocation Committee.

Specifically, I recommend the following process:

- Facilities and Asset Management will develop a facilitated process with the Lincoln and Wilson school and parent communities to provide recommendations to the Space Allocation Committee. The process should allow adequate input from stakeholders including Directors of Student Achievement, principals, parents and the community.

- This process will:

    a. Realign feeder patterns to alleviate crowding at West Sylvan Middle School and Lincoln High School.

    b. Recommend a more efficient use of our facilities consistent with the final School Size and Closure Policy. Based on the current draft, my goal is to close at least one facility in the area while preserving education options available to students within the size policy adopted by the Board.

c. Complete recommendations to the Space Allocation Committee by November 1, 2003. I would like to bring closure recommendations to the Board next year in December.

I make this recommendation for the following reasons:

- Rieke's current enrollment is 266, which is substantially larger than other schools we have closed and could be within a size policy that would be recommended to the Board.

- The Space Allocation Committee's recommendation was based largely on the limitations of the building and its location for alternative uses. Of the four schools nearby with enrollments below 300, Rieke has the smallest structure and is the most conveniently located for alternative uses. Although these are important criteria, the recommendation does not consider the potential long-term goals for most efficiently serving the neighborhood population.

- Due to past controversial boundary decisions, some nearby children are not within Rieke's boundaries. This means that, although the building is limited, the immediate surrounding area probably could support a larger enrollment.

- The past controversy involved the effect of alternative boundaries on the economic and cultural diversity of the schools in the area. It appears the proposed new boundaries (dividing the existing Rieke area between Hayhurst and Bridlemile) would not improve this situation, and could make it worse.

Standard Support Formula

One alternative to closing small schools is to reduce the amount of standard support given to each school. As part of my budget recommendations for next year which will need to include funding cuts, I will recommend a new standard school support formula.

The standard support formula provides campus monitors, counselors, child development specialists, bookkeepers, data clerks, and additional secretarial support. Music, physical education, and library staff also come from basic support in the elementary schools, as specific allocations for these activities have been cut in past budgets.

Under the proposed new formula, schools under 300 enrollment will receive disproportionately less standard support than in past years. Specifically, here is the section from the draft report developed by a team of principals concerning standard support. The full formula will be considered by the Board as part of the Superintendent's budget in April.

Here is the elementary school portion of the draft formula.

CURRENT FORMULA

Elementary Schools

Table 1

Current Elementary School Standard Support Formula

Current 2002-03 Elementary School Standard Support Formula

CALCULATED WITH NO CHANGE IN SCHOOL SIZE AND NO SCHOOL CLOSURES

FTE Allocated by School Size		<176	176-200	201-225	226-399	400-499	500-599	600+	
Number of Elementary Schools		*1*	*1*	*6*	*28*	*15*	*8*	*2*	61 Schools
Principal	113,952.30	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	
Secretary	40,885.03	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	
Basic Support	74,624.89	2.00	2.25	2.50	2.50	2.50	3.00	3.00	
Support by Size	70,054.60	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.25	1.00	1.50	2.00	
Total Elementary School Support		**4.00**	**4.25**	**4.50**	**4.75**	**5.50**	**6.50**	**7.00**	
Cost per school		**304,087**	**322,743**	**341,400**	**358,913**	**411,454**	**483,794**	**518,821**	Total
Cost for all schools		304,087	322,743	2,048,397	10,049,570	6,171,812	3,870,351	1,037,642	**$23,804,604**

Note: Enrollment includes Kindergarten students, but not students enrolled in Student Learning Centers (SLCs)

PROPOSED NEW FORMULA

Table 2a

Recommended Elementary School Formula
Using Current Schools for Cost Comparison Purposes

Recommended Elementary Standard Support Formula for 2003-04

CALCULATED WITH NO CHANGE IN SCHOOL SIZE AND NO SCHOOL CLOSURES

FTE Allocated by School Size		<250	250-299	300-399	400-499	500-599	600+		
Number of Elementary Schools		*10*	*12*	*14*	*15*	*8*	*2*	61 Schools	
215 day Principal	$106,545	1.00							
Principal	$113,952		1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00		
Asst. Prinicipal	$70,055	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	*	1.00	*May hire Asst. Principal from Support by Size FTE	
Secretary	$40,885	1.00	1.00	1.50	1.75	2.00	2.50		
Basic Support	$74,625	1.50	2.00	2.50	2.50	3.00	3.00		
Support by Size	$70,055	0.00		0.25	0.50	1.25	1.25		
Total Elementary School Support		**3.50**	**4.00**	**5.25**	**5.75**	**7.25**	**8.75**		
Cost per school		**259,368**	**304,087**	**379,356**	**407,091**	**507,165**	**597,662**	Total	
Cost for all schools		2,593,678	3,649,045	5,310,980	6,106,360	4,057,322	1,195,325	**$22,912,710**	
								$891,894	**Savings based on Table 1**
								3.7%	**Percent saved**

Note: Enrollment includes Kindergarten students, but not students enrolled in Student Learning Centers (SLCs)

Next Steps

I appreciate the work of the Space Allocation Committee in bringing forth recommendations so that the Board and the community could continue this important discussion. The Board will conduct a hearing this Thursday evening, March 6, on my recommendations and make their decisions next Monday night, March 10.

APPENDIX A Vernon Elementary and Meek Elementary Consolidation for 2003-04 School Year

DATA REVIEWED

Projected student enrollment for each school for SY 2003-04 (based on projected neighborhood students)

	Pre K	K	1	2	3	4	5	Total
Vernon	32	70	70	52	55	61	53	393
Meek	8	16	16	13	22	16	16	107
Totals	40	86	86	65	77	77	69	500

Numbers in Pre K and K can be controlled by limiting the number of transfer students.

SPACE NEEDS BASED ON PROJECTED STUDENT POPULATION

Vernon has 28 standard classroom spaces, one smaller classroom, and three office spaces outside of the main office. The proposed use for these rooms is listed below:

Standard Classrooms

1	Pre K Classroom
3	Full Day Kindergarten Classrooms
17	1st-5th Grade Classrooms
1	ESL
2	SLCB Classrooms
1	Teacher Workroom
2	Computer Labs
1	SFA Tutoring Room

Shared Areas

2	Pre K and Kindergarten Center Areas During School Time
1	First Grade Center Area During School Time
1	ERC
1	SMART

Small Classroom

1	Speech/Language

Office Spaces

1	School Psychologist
1	Student Management Specialist/Touchstone
1	Instructional Specialist

Additional Spaces

Gym
Multipurpose Room
Library
Cafeteria

FTE ALLOCATIONS (Assumptions Based on 30-1 ratio)

Pre K and Full Day Kindergarten	5.0	ECEC
Earned FTE (374 students)	12.46	
Deseg	2.75	1.5 reduction next year
School Wide Title 1	1.79	

RECOMMENDATIONS CONCERNING MOVING OF SCHOOL BOUNDARIES

Recent calculations indicate that the proposed Meek students can be transferred to Vernon assuming that the students within the Rigler and Faubion attendance areas return to their neighborhood school. If all current Meek students want to attend Vernon, the two SLCB classrooms will be moved to other locations.

EDUCATION EVALUATION

POSITIVES RESULTING FROM THE CONSOLIDATION OF MEEK AND VERNON SCHOOL A THE VERNON SITE

Success For All Tutoring would be available to both Meek and Vernon students using Experience Corp. volunteers

Facilities at Vernon include **two computer labs and a multipurpose room** not available at Meek

SMART will continue for all students

Vernon students would have access to **OASIS tutorial program**

Vernon Chess Club (one of the largest in PPS) will be made available to Meek students

Meek Partnerships would be merged with Vernon Partnerships creating a greater support for student programs and family support

Meek's strong PTA will enhance parent involvement at Vernon.

Both schools qualify as **Title 1 sites** allowing services to this population of students to continue.

Vernon has additional DESEG funds which provides for **Pre K and full day kindergarten.**

A **half time technology coordinator** at Vernon provides students and staff in grades 2-5 with instruction in publishing and Internet access.

Meek students would participate in the **Vernon RIF program.**

The school community at Vernon will grow.

There is a possibility of two on site day cares

Vernon has an **instructional specialist** that works with teachers on curriculum development that would be extended to the Meek staff

Meek students would be able to participate in **TESA** which is on line state testing allowing students multiple opportunities throughout the school year to meet state benchmarks.

Vernon has a **full time certified library position**

Meek has **after school study clubs** that could be extended to Vernon

Vernon has **SEI** that would be extended to Meek students

ISSUES FOR TRANSITION

The two schools have different literacy programs. The highly structured **Success For All program** at Vernon has resulted in significant staff development over the past six years

Meek has retained a **music program**.

Meek and Vernon staff would need to develop a common daily schedule.

Vernon staff participate in NSF math while Meek staff participate in NSF science.

Meek just completed a school improvement plan and Vernon is one year out of CSRD (a common school improvement plan would need to be developed).

Both staffs would **need to develop a common school improvement plan** and determine the reading program to be used to meet the academic needs of students.

By consolidating these two schools into one larger one, Meek would lose its small school advantage and Vernon would be on the higher end of recommended school size.

More students at Vernon will increase **traffic congestion** in the vicinity immediately around the school

All Vernon students (with the exception of SLCB) students walk to school. Adding Meek students will require **busing** which would be a financial increase to the consolidated budget

Since some students could return to Rigler and Faubion the Meek staff may need to be split among three schools. Consideration needs to be given to staff placement choices.

Planning will need to be completed and assistance will need to be provided to administration to assure a positive combining of the staffs and the development of a cohesive team.

ECONOMIC EFFICIENCY

Projected Financial Impact - Estimated Savings

Administrative Cost Savings At Closure Site	$341,400
Est. Additional Administrative Cost (due to enrollment growth at receiving schools)	-$72,340
Est. Relocation Expense	-$42,000
Est. Nutrition Services Savings	$25,000

Est. Transportation Costs	TBD
Est. Net Savings	**$252,060**

Projected Reuse

Facilities and Asset Management anticipates using Meek to house the district programs currently located at the Child Services Center. (Utility savings were removed from the potential savings.) The availability of this facility will assist the district in closing the Child Services Center which, when closed, could save up to $300,000 annually in operating costs and free up a valuable asset for sale or redevelopment.

APPENDIX B . Consolidation of Brooklyn Elementary with D.A. Grout Elementary for the 2003-2004 School Year

SPACE NEEDS BASED ON PROJECTED STUDENT POPULATION

Brooklyn is scheduled to have approximately 108 students in grades 1-5. With the need for an additional kindergarten, Grout might need an additional five classrooms. Currently available:

Basement

- Class B-located next to current Kindergarten and currently unused.

First Floor

- Room 104-Instructional and recess space for in Instructional Assistant who can be relocated to an office space.
- Room 109-Currently used as a staff room-it has been wired for the Coca Cola machine. It would be difficult, but possible, to move this space..
- Room 110-Currently houses Portland Impact, a social service agency. They might be relocated to a smaller space if the classroom is needed.

Second Floor

- Room 202-Currently empty
- Room 205-Currently a book room
- Room 208-Currently empty, however, it is part of the Reading Recovery training center and has a two way mirror located in the back. It would be unsuitable for a classroom, but would work for a replacement for the book room.

There is currently space at D.A. Grout to accommodate the maximum number of students who might move here from the Brooklyn community.

EDUCATIONAL IMPACT

Positives Resulting from the Consolidation of Brooklyn and D.A. Grout

- More program opportunities **available at Grout for Brooklyn students (for example, grade level**

classes).

- **Reading Recovery program** for first grade available at Grout.
- **Portland Impact social services** available on site at Grout.
- Programs such as **Title 1, ERC, and SMART** will continue for all students. Both schools are school-wide Title 1 schools.
- The **Arts for Learning program at D.A. Grout** will benefit Brooklyn students.
- Both schools currently use **90-minute literacy blocks** in the morning that will continue. At Grout that includes a drama program which will now be available to Brooklyn students.
- D.A. Grout has its **own playground** and does not share that facility with the nearby park.
- While state report card ratings were different (Brooklyn was rated as Strong and D.A. Grout as Satisfactory) the actual test score percentages are very similar in most areas.
- Even with consolidation, the resulting school will be fairly small at approximately 300-350 students.

ISSUES FOR TRANSITION

- Brooklyn currently uses Investigations for math, D.A. Grout uses Balanced Approach to Math. Support will need to be given to staff and students.
- It will be necessary for children from the Brooklyn neighborhood to **ride the bus** to school rather than walk.
- Brooklyn and D.A. Grout currently begin and end their day on different schedules.
- Planning will need to be completed and assistance will need to be provided to administration to assure a positive melding of the two staffs and the development of a cohesive new team.
- Activities will need to be planned for students and parents to ensure their welcome to D.A. Grout.
- The anticipated demand on YMCA daycare will necessitate trying to find additional space in the building for them to use before and after school as well as on school holidays.
- P.T.A. and Site Councils will be blended.

ECONOMIC IMPACT

The District will spend $9,500 on bus transportation. (70% will be reimbursed by the state) and approximately $14,000 relocating materials from Brooklyn to Grout.

IMPACT ON WINTERHAVEN

- Once the expansion has taken place, students will have more than one class per grade level to allow for greater social interactions.

- Expansion of this successful academic program will provide more children in the district with an opportunity to attend a science and math focus option. Following the new admissions policy of a lottery, the program allows equal access for all PPS students.

- Increasing the student population will qualify Winterhaven for status as a school rather than a program. It qualified in every aspect but size. School status provides a secretary and at least a part-time principal to the focus option if approved by the school board.

- With an increase in middle school classes, the Winterhaven students will eventually (in year three of the expansion) have enough FTE to add a foreign language and a

certified computer teacher to its staff. The vision is to become a science, math, and technology focus school. The technology piece has already begun and will continue to increase in hardware and software with each year's expansion.

PROCESS OF TRANSFERS FROM BROOKLYN TO WINTERHAVEN

- Families who wish to apply to Winterhaven must fill out the district transfer form and sign the Winterhaven Statement of Understanding. Both must be turned into Winterhaven by 4:30 on March 31.

- A lottery will take place and a computer generated list of accepted students will be produced. Students presently attending Brooklyn will be given priority status for the first five slots per grade level for the FY03-04 school year only. Those Brooklyn students not falling into the first slots (if greater than five apply) will be rerun with the rest of the district applicants for that grade level, thereby, having an additional opportunity for selection.

- The Enrollment and Transfer Center will notify all district applicants of their school selections by letter on May 1, 2003.

ECONOMIC EFFICIENCY

Projected financial Impact

- The cost of at least a part-time principal and a secretary would not be an increase in funds, since they are presently in the building.

- There would be an increase in FTE for Winterhaven because of the anticipated increase in student population. However, this could cause a decrease in FTE in other buildings do to the natural shifting of FTE when children transfer.

- There is no financial impact regarding transportation since all Winterhaven students carpool or take Tri-Met.

Projected Reuse

- Brooklyn will continue to be used by an expanded Winterhaven program.